

Chapter 3

Virgin Dhandho

By now you're likely thinking, "Look, these Patels and Manilal have done very well—my hat's off to them. It's an entertaining story, but one that clearly cannot be replicated by the rest of us. I wouldn't ever move in with my adult siblings and their families for several years to maximize our saving with the objective of building a motel empire. I'm not into working 100 hours a week or living with my family in a motel for years on end." You're probably also convinced that there is something about their family environment or gene pool that predisposes them to take this bizarre approach to life and business—the rest of us cannot embark on Dhandho journeys like them because of this difference.

To dispel that notion, let's take a look at another great Dhandho entrepreneur who is not a Patel and does not hail from Gujarat or India. He is from Surrey in England and is as flamboyant as they come. He's all about living life to the fullest and maximizing the fun. While Papa Patel and Richard Branson seemingly have nothing in common, they are inextricably linked in how they approach their business endeavors. Both are hardcore practitioners of Dhandho. Let's delve into the birth of Virgin Atlantic and learn how to start pretty much any business with minimal capital and virtually no risk—this is Dhandho on steroids.

The year was 1984 and Richard Branson knew nothing about the airline business. He started his entrepreneurial journey at 15 and was very successful in building an amazing music recording and distribution business.

Somebody sent Branson a business plan about starting an all business class airline flying between London and New York. Branson noted that when an executive in the music business received a business plan to start an airline involving a 747 jumbo jet, he knew that the business plan had been